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TURF WAR
CM M.K. Stalin (left) with Governor R.N. Ravi

TAMIL NADU

A FEDERAL FACE-OFF

By Amarnath K. Menon

Ever since the DMK came to power as the first non-Congress regime in Tamil Nadu in 1967, seldom have its governments enjoyed the best of relations with the institution of the Governor. The first DMK chief minister C.N. Annadurai often remarked that a state needs a Governor like a goat needs a beard. It's understable for a party that espouses federalism and social justice—and has been dismissed twice by the Centre, in 1976 and 1991—to carry a sharp sense of that relationship as an essentially conflictual one. So history was bound to impinge on the present when ex-IPS officer R.N. Ravi was named Tamil Nadu Governor in September 2021. Thol. Thirumavalavan, president of the DMK's alliance partner VCK (Viduthalai Chiruthaigal Katchi), acidly noted Ravi's past in the Intelligence Bureau and painted him as "someone capable of attempting to undo assertion of linguistic identities". If the situation was rife with potential for conflict, it has now been fully realised.

On April 25, Ravi was chairing a conference of vice-chancellors of state, central and private universities in the state at the Raj Bhavan in Udhagamandalam. And back in Chennai, CM M.K. Stalin got the assembly to adopt two bills intended to limit the Governor's powers and empower the state government to appoint V-Cs to 13 state universities—the Tamil Nadu Universities Laws (Amendment) Act and the Chennai University (Amendment) Act. Later that day, at a meeting to mark the end of a campaign against the National Eligibility Entrance Test (NEET) and the National Education Policy and for reclaiming the state's federal rights, Stalin lit into Ravi for tying down a bill that seeks to exempt the state from